

No Glory

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The battle had lasted four hours and changed nothing that Blackhoof could see.

The enemy line had broken by midday, and the goblin columns had pushed forward through the gap with the mechanical efficiency of men doing a job they had done before. There had been no fanfare. No pause at the crest of the hill to look back at what they had taken. The officers had simply pointed at the next objective and the army had moved, leaving its dead where they lay and its wounded to sort themselves out as best they could.

Blackhoof had done everything right. He remembered each of it with the strange clarity that came after — the tucked chin, the balanced weight, Briggs shifting correctly behind his shoulders without a word. He had taken a cut above the left foreleg in the third hour, shallow enough that it had stopped bleeding before the fighting ended, and a bruise along his right flank from a shield rim that would colour nicely by morning. Nothing more.

He had expected something to feel different.

It didn't.

Briggs had inspected him afterward with the same expression he used for checking equipment — methodical, impersonal, briefly satisfied. "You didn't die," he had said, which Blackhoof was learning to translate as high praise. Then the sergeant had gone to find target for his dice and liquid for his flask, the end of the debrief.

So Blackhoof had found a fire at the edge of camp and sat with the other young centaurs, and someone had produced a bottle of something that tasted like turpentine and ambition, and they had passed it around in the firelight while the army settled into its evening noise around them. He hadn't drunk much. Enough to soften the edges of the disappointment. Enough that when he finally lay down on his bedroll in the dark, the ground felt further away than usual and his thoughts moved slowly, like things seen through river water. He was asleep before he finished the thought.

He came awake to the weight of something across his muzzle and the sudden, complete wrongness of not being able to move.

His legs kicked before his mind caught up — instinct, pure and useless — and found them bound at the fetlocks with something that held. Hands on his shoulders, more than two pairs, pressing him down. He fought anyway, twisting hard, and felt his left elbow connect with something that gave a very satisfying crack of pain, and his right rear leg found something soft before a second rope went around his hocks and the leverage was gone.

Is it an ambush? Has the enemy get through the guards?

He couldn't shout. Couldn't see. Could only breathe through his nose in the dark and feel the hands doing their work, quick and practiced and accompanied by the kind of suppressed laughter that made him want to break things.

It was over in minutes.

Then there was silence, and retreating footsteps, and the ordinary sounds of the camp, and Blackhoof lay in the dark with his jaw clenched around the gag and waited for morning with the specific fury of someone who has nothing else available to them.

Briggs found him at dawn.

He stood in the entrance of the tent and looked at Blackhoof for a long moment without speaking. Blackhoof looked back at him. The paint was pink — enthusiastically applied, covering most of his left flank and part of his face. The glitter caught the early light with cheerful indifference. The horn on his forehead was bread, he was fairly certain, moulded and dried and fixed with something sticky.

Briggs's expression did not change.

He walked over, cut the ropes with his belt knife, removed the gag, and stepped back.

Blackhoof sat up. His head ached from the bottle and the sleepless night and the specific misery of having been lying on cold ground for four hours unable to move. He pulled the bread horn off his forehead. It came away with a sound he chose not to think about.

"Say nothing, please" he said.

"I wasn't going to say anything," said Briggs.

Briggs looked at the paint. He looked at the glitter. He looked at the bread horn in Blackhoof's hand. Something moved briefly across his face that was not quite sympathy and not quite amusement and was gone before it could be identified.

"Morning parade in twenty minutes," he said. "Get that off your face."

He left.

Blackhoof sat in the wreckage of the night and felt — beneath the anger, beneath the throbbing in his elbow, beneath the particular humiliation of the glitter — the hollow space where glory was supposed to have been. Yesterday he had done everything right. Yesterday he had been steady and correct and had not died, which was apparently the standard. And the reward for that had been a campfire and a bad bottle and someone in the dark with ropes and pink paint. He stood up, because there was nothing else to do, and went to find water.

At morning parade he saw them immediately.

Two goblins in the third rank — one with an eye swollen magnificently shut, the colour of a stormy evening, and one with a bruise on his cheekbone shaped like something that had once been a hoof. Both standing correctly, both looking forward, both radiating the careful stillness of men who hoped very much not to be looked at.

Blackhoof looked at them for exactly long enough.

Then he looked at the other young centaurs in the line — and saw, if you knew what to look for, the faint traces of it. A smear of something behind one ear. A patch of fur on a foreleg where the colour sat slightly wrong. The carefully neutral expressions of young soldiers who had spent the early morning hours scrubbing themselves and had not quite finished the job. He wasn't the only one. So some newbie ritual? May be, but what next?

He found Redhoof — the steadiest of the other young centaurs, a brother who spoke rarely and observed everything — at the water troughs after parade.

"How many?" Blackhoof asked.

"Five of them," Redhoof said, without looking up. "We tracked the paint back to their tent. Three more who weren't stupid enough to get marked up."

"All five tonight, then."

Redhoof looked at him. "What did you have in mind?"

Blackhoof told him.

A pause.

"Where do we get the glitter?" Redhoof asked.

"Same place they did." Blackhoof had already checked. The supply tent had a crate of the stuff — theatrical supplies for some regimental celebration that had never happened. "And I know where Tusk keeps the pink."

Second night in the camp was in the end much more pleasant than the first.

The morning parade found five goblins, dressed as a ladies, covered with pink color and carefully designed with glitter, roped to the flag poles. All five of them ashamed to the bones.

Briggs chose, after a brief internal consideration, not to pursue the matter. In every army the new recruits are warmly welcomed. Those just returned the favour. And after all, he was a sergeant, not a magistrate.

"Congratulations," he said, "on volunteering for latrine duty."

The one with the bruised eye tried to speak.

"All day," Briggs said. "Starting now. The old trenches need filling. The new ones need digging. After that you'll lime them — barrels are behind the supply tent — and I'd suggest working quickly, because the second trench needs to be operational by midday and there are approximately three hundred men who have been waiting for it since dawn and are not in a charitable mood." He looked down at them. "Questions?"

There were none.

"Good," said Briggs, and walked away, and did not look back at the sound of what three hundred impatient soldiers had to say to five men standing between them and a functional latrine.

He found Blackhoof at the edge of camp, watching the distant treeline with the expression he had been wearing since the battle — that particular hollowness that Briggs recognised

without pleasure, because he had worn it himself once and remembered exactly when it had arrived and what it had cost to carry.

He stood beside him and said nothing for a while.

"It wasn't what I thought it would be," Blackhoof said. Not complaining. Just stating a fact, the way a man might describe the weather.

"No," Briggs said.

"I did everything right."

"You did."

"And it was still just—" He stopped. "It was just a fight. And then it was over and we moved."

"Yes."

Blackhoof was quiet for a moment. "Does it get better?"

Briggs considered this with the seriousness it deserved.

"No," he said. "But you get better at it." He looked out at the treeline. "Different thing."

Blackhoof seemed to think about that. Then, after a moment: "The glitter won't come out of their ears for a week."

"I know," said Briggs. "I checked."

"Were we wrong in retaliation?"

"Did it felt wrong?"

Blackhoof smiled and shook his head.

Briggs turned and walked back toward camp, and behind him, for the first time since the battle, he heard Blackhoof make a sound that was not quite a laugh and not quite anything else, but was close enough.

He didn't look back, merely murmuring to himself. *No, no high expectations yet. Give him a year. Ok, a month. Bloody younglings, I fall for them every bloody time!*

